

**Benefits of Postsecondary Education Experiences for Adults with Intellectual and
Developmental Disability**

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Abstract

This article offers a comprehensive overview of the benefits of postsecondary education (PSE) for adults with intellectual and developmental disability. It describes the existing landscape of the current 339 PSE options offered by colleges and universities in the US and the relevant legislative foundations supporting program development. A brief overview of a federally funded model demonstration project, the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability program and its corresponding data on implementation and outcomes are shared. Authors review the beneficial impact college planning can have on students in both middle and high school including the importance of helping families consider college options and building academic and nonacademic skills into student education goals and planning. College based transition services are defined and research findings about the beneficial impact of attending these programs are offered. The benefits of the college search process are reviewed, describing the positive development of students having increased postsecondary program options to choose from and the relationship between choosing the right college to support a student's desired career path. The benefits of being a college student, including the benefits of learning, working, and living on campus are shared using vignettes to highlight the voices of college students with intellectual disability. Finally, the authors describe the beneficial impact of PSE for students with intellectual and developmental disability on education and service systems, including higher education, vocational rehabilitation, and disability funding sources.

Introduction

A lot of people ask me what I think makes a good college program. I think you need to have inclusive classes, not just classes only with students with intellectual disabilities. Also, it's good to have all kinds of friends and roommates and not just friends in the Excel Program. Also, parents should get on airplanes with their kids to visit colleges so they can see what the college is like before they go there. (Contreras, 2023, p.8)

A college¹ education can have a beneficial impact on various aspects of an individual's life, including their future employment, income, and social connections. College graduates have better employment prospects compared to those with only a high school diploma or less education. Additionally, many employers prefer candidates with a college degree or credential because it often signifies a higher level of knowledge and skills (Ma & Pender, 2023). College graduates are more likely to find jobs in their chosen fields, have opportunities for career advancement, and tend to earn higher incomes over their lifetimes compared to those with lower levels of education (Trostel, 2015). Additional benefits of college include the opportunity to develop valuable social connections throughout students' lives. These connections may be in the form of friendships, professional networks, and mentors and can lead to future job referrals, collaborations, and other beneficial relationships both personally and professionally (Cox, 2021). College also fosters personal growth and development, providing a chance to explore different interests, develop critical thinking skills, and gain exposure to diverse perspectives and experiences.

Each of these positive adult outcomes may be desirable, regardless of a person's background, though background including socioeconomic status, race, ethnicity, geographic

¹ In the U.S. the term college is used generally to refer to any form of postsecondary or undergraduate education; colleges and universities both offer undergraduate degrees. The term college students includes students attending either a 2-year or 4-year college or a university.

location, and family may strongly impact the likelihood of an individual's chance to reap these benefits. Until recently, people with intellectual disability have largely been excluded from college and its associated benefits. Until the early 21st century, few colleges and universities in the United States provided access to students with intellectual disability. This scarcity of postsecondary education (PSE) opportunities and prevalent low expectations for success prevented students from pursuing education after high school. Students with intellectual disability are the least likely disability group to have college listed as a goal on their Individual Education Program (IEP; Grigal, et al., 2011). Consequently, this is also one of the least likely groups of students (along with students with multiple disabilities) to enroll in PSE 4 years after high school (Newman et al., 2009). A recent report from the National Core Indicators 2020–2021 In-Person Survey found only 3.2% of respondents with intellectual and developmental disability (IDD) aged 18–25 were enrolled in a college or university (National Core Indicators, 2022).

This aligns with earlier data from the National Longitudinal Transition Study-2 that indicated only 2.3% of out-of-school youth in the United States with intellectual disability were enrolled in any kind of PSE institution National Longitudinal Transition Study-2 (2009). While some PSE options for students with intellectual disability existed in the late 1990s and early 2000s, there was no federal or state guidance or funding available to support these efforts. Thus, early PSE programs were funded by grants or by fundraising efforts by parents, donors, or non-profit organizations (Neubert et al., 2001). The focus and activities of each program varied widely, as did the profiles of the students served. Some programs offered access to inclusive courses and social experiences whereas others offered substantially separate learning experiences in segregated classes attended only by students with intellectual disability (Hart et al., 2004).

Some programs enrolled adult students who were no longer enrolled in high school.

Others provided a transition education experience in a college setting to students who were still entitled to special education services through their school district between the ages of 18 and 22 (depending on the state). At the time, these were called dual enrollment programs. Most of the dual enrollment programs were operated by school districts, enrolled a small number of students, focused on employment, and provided some inclusion with same-age peers, independent living skills, and participation in college classes. Classes taken for credit were vocational and remedial classes; academic, health and fitness, and arts classes were taken informally or audited (Papay & Bambara, 2011).

A national study conducted in 2009 described the existing landscape of PSE programs prior to the implementation of new U.S. federal guidance and funding that occurred in 2010. Respondents from 149 programs in institutions of higher education in 39 states indicated they served students with intellectual disability. The findings from this survey provided information on the types of colleges and universities involved and revealed that the primary focus of most programs was independent living or life skills, not academic access (Grigal et al., 2012).

The Higher Education Opportunity Act of (2008) amended the Higher Education Act and led to significant changes in the availability of PSE options for students with intellectual disability in the United States. The HEOA (2008) created a way for students with intellectual disability to access federal financial aid for PSE through a designation called Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary (CTP) programs. To achieve this designation, colleges and universities hosting a program enrolling students with intellectual disability must apply to the Office of Federal Student Aid to become an approved CTP program by documenting their capacity to meet certain regulatory criteria (Wertenberger, 2020). The HEOA legislation also authorized funding for a new model demonstration program called the Transition and

Postsecondary Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSID). This program, overseen by the U.S. Department of Education's Office of Postsecondary Education, provided funds via a competitive grant process to institutions of higher education interested in developing, enhancing, or expanding PSE programs for students with intellectual disability. The TPSID program was the first national effort requiring funded PSE programs to implement services aligned with the new federal guidance.

The legislation also funded a National Coordinating Center (NCC) to provide technical assistance and evaluate the implementation of the TPSID program. This Center was also charged with developing model accreditation standards and providing technical assistance to colleges and universities, K-12 local education agencies, families and students, and others interested in developing, expanding, or improving PSE for people with intellectual disability in the United States. Since its inception in 2010, the NCC has been operated by Think College at the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston. Think College is a national organization aimed at improving college access and outcomes for students with intellectual disability. Its website offers a searchable directory of PSE programs in the United States, state specific information related to policy and legislation, a searchable resource library, data and evaluation reports, and a national help desk. To learn more about PSE program development, implementation and evaluation readers are encouraged to visit <https://thinkcollege.net>.

The TPSID model demonstration program led to the creation or expansion of 134 PSE programs at colleges or universities in the United States, enrolling over 4500 students with intellectual disability between 2010 and 2023. Two additional institutions have administered TPSID grants supporting the development of programs at other colleges and universities (see Figure 1). Data from the TPSID grantees between 2010 and 2023 documented that students with

intellectual disability have enrolled in almost 64,000 courses and obtained over 2600 individual paid jobs while enrolled. These data have also shown the strong employment outcomes for students with intellectual disability who attend these programs: 74% of TPSID graduates who responded to a follow-up survey had paid employment 1 year after graduating, and 70% had a paid job after two years (Grigal et al., 2024). These numbers are substantially higher than the 16% of adults with IDD in the general population who have paid work (National Core Indicators, 2023).

The colleges and universities implementing PSE programs using funds from the TPSID model demonstration program represent only about one-third of the PSE programs in the country. Many other colleges and universities have created programs using other sources of funding including funds from states; state developmental disability (DD) agencies including home and community-based waiver funds; vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies; foundations; and non-profit or philanthropic donors. As of June 2024, a directory of U.S. PSE programs enrolling students with intellectual disability lists 339 programs, with at least one program in every state except Wyoming (see Figure 2).

PSE for students with intellectual disability is sometimes referred to as *inclusive postsecondary education*. Although all the PSE programs referenced above enroll students with intellectual disability, not all these colleges and universities provide these students with the same degree of access to inclusive academic courses. Inclusive courses are defined as academic courses taught by faculty as part of the typical course offerings of the college or university and attended by matriculating students, allowing them to enroll in typical college courses with peers without and with other disabilities (Grigal et al., 2022).

However, some PSE programs may deliver only courses in non-inclusive or segregated

environments, with specialized curricula for students with intellectual disability that are separate from traditional college options (Grigal et al., 2021). Other programs may offer blended experiences of both inclusive and specialized courses. To ensure an accurate representation of the full universe of programs and to prevent over-generalizing the level of inclusion programs provide, we use the term *postsecondary education* (PSE) programs in this narrative.

PSE programs in the United States also vary significantly in how they are implemented. A study in 2022 reflected about half of the PSE programs in the United States were operated at a 4-year university, with fewer at community colleges or career and technical schools. Just over a third of the PSE programs were two years in length and 28% indicated the length of the program varied from student to student. Only 13% were 4-year programs. Most programs (84%) indicated they enrolled students with intellectual disability and autism and over a third indicated they enrolled students with other disabilities (Grigal et al., 2022). To learn more about the PSE programs' approaches to academics, career development and employment, and residential and campus life, we recommend readers review the full study. In this chapter, we review the benefits of PSE for students with intellectual disability. We begin by reviewing the impact on the experiences of students who are transitioning from high school to adult life including the benefits of going through the college search process. We then review the benefits of being a college student, including the benefits of learning, working, and living on campus, and the benefits of completing college. We end with a review of the beneficial impact of PSE for students with intellectual disability on education and service systems, including higher education, VR, and disability funding sources. Throughout, we use vignettes to highlight the voices of college students with intellectual disability.

Benefits of Postsecondary Education

Beneficial Impact on Middle and High School Transition Experiences

Students with intellectual disabilities need to start thinking and learning about postsecondary education when they are in middle school. Special educators need to be talking about transition planning with students with intellectual disability and their families as early as possible. Attending college fairs and getting information about various programs can be helpful. Gathering support from family, friends, special educators, teachers, and instructional aides is very important. Transition planning helps plan for a person's future, including college education and employment. Transition planning must be based on a person-centered approach, and it also uses a family-centered approach. IQ is just a number. We want to be valued, respected, and meaningfully employed members of our communities just like everyone else.

Postsecondary education can help achieve this. (Peebles, 2023, p.17)

The existence of college options for students with intellectual disability has a potentially beneficial impact on student middle and high school transition experiences. In the United States, transition services to support the movement of youth with disabilities from high school to adult life are mandated by federal law to commence at age 16, and begin even earlier in some states (Madaus et al., 2024). Although transition services typically begin in high school (Grades 9–12), conversations about long term plans can and should occur in middle school (Grades 7–8) or earlier, as too often the goals on a student's IEP may not reflect long term high expectations for college and careers (Grigal et al., 2019). Educational organizations including the National Association for College Admission Counseling (2016) recommends college and career planning begins in middle school to ensure students have sufficient time to explore their options and plan accordingly (Wimberly & Noeth, 2005).

Students with intellectual disability in middle and high school may not be encouraged to consider college as an option due to a lack of awareness of their families or the professionals creating their education plans (Grigal & Papay, 2018a). Middle and secondary educators may not be aware of the current PSE options available to students with intellectual disability, especially if options are not prevalent in their state or region. However, by informing students, families, and educators of the possibility of future college enrollment, middle and high school students with intellectual disability can be better prepared if they choose to pursue a college education. Prior to high school, educators can support middle school students with intellectual disability to become more aware of their interests and skills through self-reflection and exploration. Preparation in high school can include supporting students and families in understanding the differences between high school and college and developing academic and non-academic skills for PSE. Educators, armed with the knowledge that college is an option for students with intellectual disability, can infuse students' IEPs and transition plans with goals aligned with future college success (Becht, 2022). This planning can focus on skills such as use of technology to support time management, communication, campus navigation, self-advocacy, speaking up and asking for needed supports, and using electronic information (e.g., websites, apps) to identify future learning, career development, or personal interest opportunities. Goals can also focus on the college search process and include opportunities to attend college fairs or conduct college visits, fill out financial aid forms, and complete college applications.

Additionally, high school students with intellectual disability may explore their future interest in attending college by attending a college-based transition program. College-based transition services (CBTS), also known in some states as dual enrollment or concurrent enrollment, provide students with intellectual disability access to college courses, internships,

and employment, as well as opportunities to participate in clubs and other organizations during their final 2–3 years of secondary education (Grigal & Bass, 2018; Paiewonsky & Shahrzad, 2020; Schillaci et al., 2021). College-based transition programs have a strong focus on supporting students to engage in employment and work-based learning (Papay, Grigal, & Choiseul-Praslin, 2023). Although not as prevalent as the PSE programs for adult students with intellectual disability, there are at least 90 PSE institutions in the United States offering CBTS to transition-age youth (Think College, 2024).

College-based transition programs are an effective way to prepare youth for future college enrollment. A recent study found typical transition services for youth with intellectual disability and autism offered relatively low access to most PSE preparation activities whereas CBTS programs for students with intellectual disability and autism prepared students for future PSE and were more likely to use research-based practices (Papay, et al., 2023). Other studies found the CBTS approach effective in supporting employment preparation (Papay, et al., 2023) and the development of self-determination: Schillaci et al. (2021) found that a single year of participation in a CBTS program led to significant increases in students' autonomy, self-initiation, psychological empowerment, and self-realization.

Benefits of the College Search Process

The process of researching, visiting, and selecting a college is often a milestone of self-direction for young adults in the United States and in various other places in the world. As the field of inclusive postsecondary education continues to grow and the availability of PSE programs for students with intellectual disability increases, students with intellectual disability are now engaging in this process similarly to their peers entering college through a matriculated pathway. In the past students with intellectual disability might have had only one or two colleges

to choose from, if they were even offered the chance to consider college. Now, with the growth of PSE options, students with intellectual disability in the United States are touring college campuses, attending college fairs, and weighing college options.

Students and their families are considering information about the different opportunities, including opportunities to be with peers, access to particular majors, and support available at each program. These prospective students, much like their prospective matriculated peers, are tasked with determining if they want a small or large setting, a college or university with residential options or one where all students commute, and a variety of academic and social options. Having this choice between multiple institutions for future courses of study provides students with intellectual disability the opportunity for autonomy and self-direction previously not available to this population of young adults.

As more students with intellectual disability are engaging in the college search process, completing college is becoming an expectation for some students rather than a rare accomplishment. Given this, students with intellectual disability, much like their matriculated peers, have increased expectations for these institutions and programs. Soldovieri and Myers (in press) explored the expectations of students with intellectual disability applying for college. Their findings indicated that these prospective students expected their college program would be truly and fully inclusive, with opportunities to learn and socialize alongside matriculated peers, aid in their growth to be as independent as possible, and provide access to academic learning. Applicants further described features of their desired program not typically made available to students with intellectual disability, such as studying abroad. This finding indicates a shift from asking for permission (to be on campus, be a college student, etc.) to claiming real ownership over their experience. This kind of ownership has only recently become possible as students with

intellectual disability demand full community member status within higher education, beginning with the college search process.

Students are now sometimes selecting colleges based on particular features, such as availability of majors or certificate programs. In one application, a prospective college student indicated, “I would like to attend here because of the support systems and the variety of majors offered here. The plan is to pursue a career in Marketing and Music. I have participated in music programs since I was seven years old and am still committed to music as of now” (Soldovieri & Myers (in press) Why students with intellectual disability apply to college. *British Journal of Learning Disabilities.*, n.p.). This is a small, yet often taken for granted assumption for those applying for college via a matriculated pathway; for students with intellectual disability the ability to choose a program tailored to their interests is a relatively new development.

Benefits of Being a College Student

I am now in my second year of the four-year college program at Georgia Tech. I am taking four classes—Science Foundations of Health, the World Today, Financial Literacy, and Career Success II... I like going to college because I am learning how to be independent. I can take Lyft by myself from home to the airport and take the plane to Atlanta, and I can take the MARTA train from the airport to the Midtown station and walk four blocks to my apartment. My mom helps me plan my meals every week with a spreadsheet. I use Instacart to order my groceries from Publix or Sprouts. I am learning how to make my own meals. I make my own chiropractor appointments and dentist appointments and flu shot appointments... I also like being at a college where there are a lot of different kinds of people. I am half Mexican American and half Filipino American. I have three roommates. One of them is half African American and half Filipino American,

and the other two roommates are white. One of my classmates is from Switzerland. There are a lot of international students at Georgia Tech. One of my classmates was a foster kid for most of his life. I have classmates who are from all over Georgia and from other states. We are all different, and that's cool. (Contreras, 2023, p. 7–8)

Students with intellectual disability report a range of personal and professional benefits of the college experience. These include identity development, access to college-specific experiences, the ability to “move into adulthood”, and expanding social networks, much like other matriculated college students. Further, these benefits are particularly salient for students with intellectual disability who are considered to have complex support needs (e.g., individuals with intellectual disability who are nonspeaking, those with co-occurring psychiatric conditions, etc.). These students are uniquely positioned to benefit from PSE as their constellations of needs and supports are unlikely to be met within other settings, particularly within segregated settings.

One of the benefits of college for many students is the opportunity to explore and develop a new sense of identity. For some students, this includes the development of a career identity towards future employment (Uditsky & Hughson, 2012). For many students, college is an opportunity to explore hobbies and interests, join clubs and organizations, find like-minded people who share niche interests, or even to try completely new things. College can be a place to try anything from the gaming club to the belly dancing troupe. As described by Uditsky and Hughson (2012), this complex experience,

means being able to authentically act on one's passions, hopes, and dreams, as well as one's, academic interests. It is not enough just to be on campus. It is far more necessary to belong, to establish relationships—whether as part of a team, student council, student advisory body, study group, cohort of peers in the same faculty, or faith group. (p. 299)

Students often value the opportunities a college campus offers to access to athletics, arts, activities, sporting, and social events.

For many, this is a time to explore a new identity as a college student. For some students, this is the first time they have explored their identity as a disabled person. Some become involved in disability culture or activism groups on their campuses and begin to explore issues of disability justice. For others, it is the first time identifying with disability in a non-negative way and finding a community of those who proudly identify as disabled. Alternatively, some students may distance themselves from their identity as a disabled person and instead embrace other aspects of their identities and interests; college is, after all, a time of great self-exploration. For some this means understanding and exploring their disability identity in conversation with other marginalized identities and for others it means exploring an additional marginalized identity. A diverse population of people and social groups make possible identity explorations that might not have occurred in high school or prior. For example, if you were the only fan of an obscure manga comic in your high school, you might find that you can be a member of a whole club in college.

Further, college can be a place to make mistakes with a safety net, a space for young people to try new things, explore independence, and work out their errors while significant support is available. Embedded into the matriculated college experience for young people is that this is a time to take risks, make mistakes, and find out who they are. This has since expanded to not only matriculated college students but also those with intellectual disability; mirroring the concept of dignity of risk (Bumble et al., 2021). Inclusive college life (as what Uditsky (1993) referred to as a normative pathway (Uditsky, 1993)) not only facilitates necessary improvement in independent living skills (i.e., laundry, cooking, managing one's finances, hygiene) for students with intellectual disability (Ryan et al., 2019) but allows for a naturally occurring

scaffolded approach to self-directed decision making without the need for a segregated or specialized space/program.

PSE programs for students with intellectual disability can further support this authentic learning in inclusive spaces by adopting and implementing the College and Career Learning Model (CCLM), a framework which mirrors the four-year planning many matriculated college students engage within their academic program. Within this model students “work on skills of their choosing that are directly related to their own personal goals for their future” (Burke & Becht, 2022, p. 2). By first engaging in Person Centered Planning, students with intellectual disability (often with the support of program staff and/or mentors) develop an overall plan of the skills and goals that are currently important and the skills and goals that will be important for their future. Students work alongside program staff and/or peer mentors to review their strengths and areas for potential goals within a scope of college and career skills identified as critical to students with and without disabilities (Hart et al., 2017). These college and career skills exist within four domains: academic and career habits, community engagement, balance of multiple roles, and self-direction (Burke & Becht, 2022). Students then self-select short- and long-term goals and identify corresponding experiences (i.e., classes, university clubs, internships, etc.) and work alongside program support staff and/or peer mentors to document progress toward a student identified goal. Within this process students are also actively engaged in determining the support needed providing a continued opportunity for students with intellectual disability to not only understand their support needs but also practice these advocacy skills.

Benefits of Learning

I took a class called Introduction to Poetry in the fall semester in 2012. I learned how to analyze poems, how to write haiku. I also learned a lot about different types of poetry.

The class was fun, but it was extremely tough. I didn't realize this course would be so academically rigorous. I took the class independently without a mentor from a third of the way through the semester, and I made new friends in class. I worked on a group project on Langston Hughes. In the group project, we incorporated a wonderful YouTube video spotlighting Hughes reading his own poetry. My favorite poets are Robert Frost and Sylvia Plath. I did another analytical research paper on two poems by Sylvia Plath. I spent many hours in the library and utilized the undergraduate writing center. During my time in this poetry course, I analyzed poems and completed a research paper on Robert Frost. Writing the Robert Frost paper was difficult work. (Peebles, 2023, p. 13–14)

Becht et al. (2020) describe three types of academic access in PSE programs: liberal arts courses, career and technical education, and transitional classes. In many PSE programs, students work towards a certificate or a credential instead of a bachelor's or associate degree (Gibbons et al., 2015; Grigal et al., 2013). In some programs, students with intellectual disability have access to the full range of courses at the university. In others, students with intellectual disability take a prescribed set of courses that are part of a specific certificate program. Sometimes, students take courses for credit and sometimes courses are audited, depending on the college or university's policies and the match between the student and the course expectations. The credentials earned are most frequently culminating program certificates, awarded by the university or by the program itself. In some cases, these credentials are coupled with microcredentials or industry recognized credentials. Though less frequent, students may be working toward an associate or bachelor's degree. Students may receive advising from PSE program staff, from typical college advisors, or both. Students accessing college through a PSE program should have opportunities to access the same academic and social activities as matriculated students (Hart et al., 2006); and

not be limited to a separate program or only separate classes delivered on the campus of a college or university.

Students with intellectual disability who complete a PSE program gain numerous benefits, and these benefits mirror the personal gains of matriculated college students (Weir, 2004). Given college has long been known as a time to expand a young person's academic horizons, it makes sense that the same holds true for students with intellectual disability in a PSE program. College applicants to one program have noted, "I hope that while I attend the (program) I can refine my interests and develop my knowledge base" (Soldovieri & Myers (in press) Why students with intellectual disability apply to college. *British Journal of Learning Disabilities.*, n.p.). Another notes "I want to take college classes to broaden my knowledge. I would like to find classes that interest me." (n.p.) These remarks demonstrate how these two future college students expected to engage in academic pursuits through university classes with necessary support, similar to the expectations of matriculating college peers.

Supports for Learning

In college in the United States disabled students themselves are responsible for disclosing a disability in order to access accommodations, usually by registering through a university sanctioned process through its disability services office. This office communicates with instructors, and course instructors are then typically responsible for approving and implementing accommodations in the classroom. At some PSE programs, students with intellectual disability follow this process and procedure. In other cases, PSE program staff coordinate course access, accommodations, and support available only to students with intellectual disability, such as course modifications. Although PSE programs are often intended to provide a bridge between students and university systems to support academic access, the onus often falls on PSE

programs to ensure necessary support is given. University professors are rarely given formal instruction on how to support students with intellectual disability or how to adapt instruction in the college setting (Smith & Myers, 2024). Despite these hurdles, studies report students with intellectual disability gain numerous benefits from being educated in regular college classes and with matriculated peers (Gibbons et al., 2015; Weir, 2004).

Often, students with intellectual disability in PSE programs receive support in class from a peer (matriculated college student) mentor who can help them take notes, participate in class, complete individual or group work, organize materials, implement modifications, prioritize course work, or understand content (Carter et al., 2019; Carter & McCabe, 2021; Smith & Myers, 2024). Mentors might also help with homework, tutoring, or navigating to and from class. In some programs, peer mentors support the implementation of course accommodations. One benefit of a peer mentor as compared to staff support is peers are often more knowledgeable of student issues and able to facilitate more authentic social inclusion through the formalized classroom environment given their inherent community member status.

Other benefits to students include learning self-advocacy skills to request accommodations (Brendli et al., 2021; Hall Pistorio et al., 2021), increased academic skills, and access to a rigorous curriculum (Smith & Myers, 2024). Some PSE programs provide specific academic interventions such as written expression development or reading support (Ford & Kaldenberg, 2019; Hua et al., 2019; Shelton et al., 2019). University faculty who teach students with intellectual disability in college courses have been found to be more inclusive overall, have increased disability awareness, have stronger pedagogical skills, and are more focused on classroom engagement (Carey et al., 2022; Hall Pistorio et al., 2021; McCabe et al., 2022; Taylor et al., 2021). Universities with a PSE program often emphasize Universal Design for Learning

frameworks in the college classroom (Love et al., 2019). Many of these characteristics of practice intended to benefit students with intellectual disability on the college campus result in practices beneficial to all students.

Benefits of Working

As a person with an intellectual disability, I was given opportunities and chances to go to college and experience life on a college campus. I would never have gotten a meaningful job at the University of Vermont without having participated in the Think College Vermont program. My video work with Green Mountain Self-Advocates was a direct result of what I learned from my internships. All people with intellectual and developmental disabilities need to be given opportunities to have postsecondary education experiences that can lead them to meaningful employment in the community. The first step is to ask students with intellectual disability what they want to do in their future. Some students might want to be poets, artists, computer scientists, filmmakers, or game developers. (Peebles, 2023, p. 16–17)

An important benefit of attending a PSE program is the expectation that employment is the goal. Multiple studies have documented the low expectations held for future employment of transition-age youth with intellectual disability (Choiseul-Praslin et al., 2022; Doren et al., 2012; Mazzotti et al., 2016). The impact of these low outcomes persists into adulthood, with significantly lower employment rates for those individuals with intellectual disability whose families held low expectations (Mazzotti et al., 2016). PSE programs for students with intellectual disability are designed to prepare students for employment, and those programs approved as CTP programs and those receiving TPSID grant funds are required to prepare students for gainful employment (U.S. Department of Education, Office of Postsecondary

Education, 2015). As a result, students enrolling in these PSE programs are expected to engage in experiences to prepare for a career after graduation. Indeed, for many students in PSE programs, the job or internship they have in the program is their first opportunity to gain paid work experience. For example, in 2022–2023, 41% of students at TPSIDs who were employed had no prior work experience (Grigal et al., 2024).

Students with intellectual disability who enroll in PSE programs receive a wide array of support for career development. According to data from the TPSID model demonstration program, 97% of students attending TPSIDs in 2022–2023 engaged in at least one career preparation activity, such as career awareness and exploration, work-based learning, job-seeking, or paid employment (Grigal et al., 2024). Career awareness and exploration activities such as company tours, job shadowing, resume writing, and completing interest inventories are the most widely used form of career preparation: In the same academic year, 94% of students at TPSIDs engaged in these activities. These kinds of activities allow students to broaden their career awareness, which should have been developed during their K-12 education and transition services but which many students with intellectual disability enter college without (Domin et al., 2020).

On-campus student employment can provide college students with opportunities to develop career-readiness skills (Burnside et al., 2019). A college campus provides an ideal location for accessing a wide array of work experiences through work study, paid and unpaid internships, service learning, and student employment. Coupled with career development support from a dedicated program (Petcu et al., 2015), PSE programs that include a focus on employment are an effective way to prepare students with intellectual disability for a career, similar to peers.

Researchers have documented the importance of early paid work experience for future

employment (Carter et al., 2012). An important benefit of enrolling in PSE is the opportunity for paid employment with support. In the 2022–2023 academic year, 65% of students at TPSID programs were engaged in paid work, either through paid employment or a paid work-based learning experience (Grigal et al., 2024). The percentage of students at TPSIDs who are accessing paid work experiences has increased over time, demonstrating the commitment of these programs to ensuring this evidence-based practice is incorporated into their career preparation. Importantly, accessing support for employment through a PSE program allows for a focus on preparation for a career and not just a job. An employment coordinator at a TPSID program who participated in a focus group by Domin et al. (2020) described it this way:

I think we've set up our program to help the students explore the possibilities that are out there, and not just entry-level burger-flipping kind of thing, but something that they really want to do. And then we prepare them to be competitive when they're applying for that job. (p. 335)

However, research has also documented that access to paid employment while enrolled in college is not equally accessible to all students with intellectual disability enrolled in PSE programs. Grigal et al. (2019) found students who attended their PSE program for more years and those who enrolled in fewer specialized courses were more likely to obtain paid employment while enrolled. The researchers suggested this could indicate students are more likely to be supported to obtain paid employment later in their program with a focus on unpaid experience at first, and that devoting more staff time to specialized coursework could mean fewer staff resources for job development and networking with employers. Given that paid employment while enrolled has been found to be a predictor of paid employment after program completion (Carter et al., 2012; Grigal et al., 2019), it is important for those working in the field of inclusive

postsecondary education to continue to ensure efforts are made to support access to paid employment for all college students with intellectual disability.

Benefits of Living on Campus

On Friday and Saturday nights when it was too cold (or we were feeling a little lazy), we would lay out blankets and gather our favorite junk food to enjoy relaxing movie nights. If we were feeling more social (which was usually the case), we would join friends for university-sponsored late-night recreation (Orange After Dark Events). Since we both love to dance, we joined the Orange Pulse Dance Troupe together and enjoyed practicing for the annual showcase with fellow dance and music lovers. Sometimes we wanted to go off on our own roommate adventures off-campus, just the two of us! We would go for walks in the park or around the city, take a bus to the mall, or play in the snow. Looking back, one of our favorite roommate trips was to Barnes & Noble... Not all of our roommate bonding or general college silliness involved leaving campus. Our fun didn't have to be super planned or structured! There were a million places on campus to explore, and we enjoyed walking around to find the coolest spots together. Sometimes, if we found a particularly cool spot, we would stake it out. (Baist & Walter, 2023, p. 47–48)

There are extensive benefits to college beyond formal academic learning and career preparation. Existing literature indicates critical skills needed for increased levels of independence are learned through navigating the experience at a college or university (Vinoski Thomas et al., 2020). While residence hall life for undergraduate students as a bridge to the campus community can ultimately benefit students academically (Pascarella & Terenzini, 2005), another major benefit is fostering independent living skills. One of the desired outcomes for those who have completed PSE programs is in(ter)dependent living (Bacon & Baglieri, 2021).

Each year college and university residence halls and off campus apartments become students' homes for the year. In the United States, it is common for students to live at their colleges or universities, and many universities have a minimum number of years that students must live in school sponsored residence halls. For students with intellectual disability who access college through a PSE program, a growing number of programs offer support for students to live with their matriculated peers in residence halls and off campus apartments. Access to living on or around campus like their peers ensures students who attend college through a PSE program have access to the full range of benefits college offers.

College is also a chance to gently transition into adulthood, an opportunity many matriculated students get but has been historically denied to individuals with intellectual disability. When a student goes to college, they have a unique ecosystem with embedded natural supports to work on independent living, academic, career, and interpersonal skills, often in increasingly challenging steps. For example, a first-year student may live in a residence hall, learn to negotiate with a roommate, do laundry, care for their personal space, manage their schedule and academics, etc. Yet they eat in the dining hall where the cooking is done for them, and common spaces are cleaned and managed by college staff. Depending on the university's requirements, students either remain in this structure or gradually move to off campus housing where they may or may not have a resident advisor (RA) and are responsible for cleaning spaces and cooking meals. Although this is not a universal experience, it is certainly more common for matriculated college students to have this gentle shift into adulthood, what Uditsky (1993) refers to as a normative pathway, than their counterparts with intellectual disability, who more often experience transition as a sudden cliff.

Specifically for students with intellectual disability, PSE programs may elect to

implement specific student directed goal setting, monitoring, and inclusive experiences with student directed support through the CCLM frame discussed above. Beyond these tangible independent skills (i.e., budgeting, meal preparation, laundry etc.) that are needed for independent living, it is also important for students accessing college through a PSE program to develop confidence and skills to advocate for themselves (O'Brien & Bonati, 2019). These skills are necessary for success during and after college and to lead a self-directed life. This begins with mirroring their matriculated peers, by transferring communication with the school to the student rather than parents or guardians in an environment where safeguards are in place. Mock and Love (2012) found this shifting of responsibility, vis a vis students taking the role of primary contact for college communication, was a desire of students accessing college via PSE programs. Postsecondary education programs need to intentionally develop opportunities for students to better understand their own needs and navigate how to get support.

Living on campus further gives students in PSE programs increased opportunity to participate in all aspects of campus life including social aspects such as clubs, cultural events, and sporting events (Carter & McCabe, 2021; Grigal & Papay, 2018b; Hendrickson et al., 2013). Involvement in these social activities provides additional avenues for students to discover their interests, preferences, and desires as well as learn skills to navigate campuses (Hendrickson et al., 2013). While access to formal recreational and social events such as clubs and sporting events may be open to all students, those who live on campus are more likely to have natural informal social opportunities in addition to these structured social activities.

Some PSE programs put a number of residential supports in place for students. One such support is that of a peer mentor and/or RA (also called a residential mentor) who is a fellow undergraduate student typically without an intellectual disability (Carter et al., 2019; Carter &

McCabe, 2021; Grigal et al., 2019). These mentors and RAs provide an additional level of support not offered to students outside of the PSE program. They assist students in the PSE program with executive function support relating to hygiene, time management, space and materials, and interpersonal relationships with others on campus. One of the innate benefits of programs using peers is their position within the campus community. As these peers are supporting students in the PSE program in structured ways, they are simultaneously serving as a catalyst for unstructured involvement (Carter & McCabe, 2021; Christopher-Allen et al., 2017; Grigal et al., 2021).

Benefits of Completing College

Up until App State, all of my former teachers, with the exception of a few, said I had no future, and my job choices would be picking up trash and working in retail. I was in the occupational courses of study program where you learn and find job placement, but they said I would never go to college. Here I am, years later, accepted into my third university. Without a program like SDAP we would be stuck with no social life or career path. (Thomas, 2023, p. 88)

At the point of program completion, students with intellectual disability have experienced many benefits of PSE. We reiterate some of those key benefits in this section and explain how those benefits extend further into adult life. Students with intellectual disability who complete a college program have built skills in a range of areas important for adult life. These areas include independent living (Ryan et al., 2019), transportation and navigation (Hendrickson et al., 2017; Ryan, 2014), socialization (Hendrickson et al., 2017), and adaptive behavior (i.e., ability to function independently at home and in the community; Prohn et al., 2018). Results of outcome surveys of graduates from PSE programs have found them to be more engaged in their

communities, more likely to have friends, and in better health than comparison samples of adults with intellectual disability (Butler et al., 2016). Graduates report high levels of satisfaction with their social lives (Grigal et al., 2024) and many are able to achieve residential independence away from their family (Grigal et al., 2024; Ross et al., 2013). It is clear the PSE experience has contributed to these successful social and independent living outcomes.

The experience of being around peers without disability, or with other disabilities, at a critical stage of the transition from young adult to adulthood is an important aspect of engaging in a PSE experience. Through the peer support available to individuals with intellectual disability who enroll in college, as well as natural opportunities for making friends, college students with intellectual disability build adult social networks that will continue even after they graduate. Friends made in college can become future roommates and can provide connections for future job opportunities.

The career development and employment experiences, coupled with credentials, position graduates of PSE programs to obtain employment in their desired careers. Numerous studies have documented these individuals with intellectual disability work at higher rates, earn more, and rely less on Supplemental Security Income benefits than adults with intellectual disability in the general population (Avellone, 2021; Sannicandro et al., 2018). These successful employment outcomes are due in large part to the aforementioned career awareness and exploration activities students complete as part of their PSE programs as well as the vocational-related support services available to students with intellectual disability in PSE programs, including person-centered planning, career-focused training, and connections with adult service agencies (Petcu et al., 2015).

Individuals with intellectual disability have also learned an important skill: how to access

further education as an adult. In surveys of TPSID program completers, some graduates reported they accessed further education in the first year after program completion (Grigal et al., 2024), indicating that their PSE program is not the endpoint for their education. These individuals have learned where to find opportunities for further education, whether it is to advance their career or to engage in learning for personal interest. This skill will have a lasting impact as they progress through their careers and adult lives.

Beneficial Impact on Education and Service Systems

The emergence and growth of the field of inclusive postsecondary education and its corresponding growth in college opportunities for students with intellectual disability has had a variety of beneficial impacts on related higher education and adult systems.

Benefits to Higher Education

The capacity of higher education to respond to the needs of students with disabilities in general has grown in the past 20 years. Students with an array of disabilities and corresponding support needs have been attending college and receiving accommodations from disability services offices. In meeting requirements under the Americans with Disabilities Act of (1990) (PL 101–336) and the more recent Americans with Disabilities Act Amendments Act of (2008) (PL 110–325) as well as Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of (1973) (PL 93–112), institutions of higher education have developed more robust systems for students to self-identify as having a disability, to document their support needs, and to receive supports or accommodations they need to make academic progress. This foundation of support is often the place many PSE programs begin development.

Although the disability support structures used by those without intellectual disability, such as the disability services or ADA compliance office are necessary to respond to the needs of

those with intellectual disability; they are not sufficient to create a successful PSE experience. The unique and holistic goals of PSE programs, to address students' academic, career development, independent living, and self-determination needs, require engagement from additional campus partners beyond the disability services or ADA office. Program development entails collaboration between academic parts of a campus, faculty, and advising staff as well as college and university administrators to address policy and fiscal concerns (Freedman et al., 2022; May, 2022).

Additionally, involvement is needed from the financial aid office if the program is seeking to offer federal student aid to students; from the bursar and registrar offices for course enrollment and payment; and from the housing and student life staff for those students living on and off campus. The interdisciplinary team involved in planning builds stronger understanding about students with intellectual disability attending the program and broader ownership of both the students and the program's success. A strong system of peers involved with every program in either formal ways (such as peer mentors or education coaches) or informal ways (such as being in classes with students or living as roommates in dorms) also has documented benefits. Peer mentors indicate mentoring experiences improve their professional trajectories, personal perspectives, attitudes toward others, and interpersonal relationships (Carter & McCabe, 2021). The data from the TPSID programs offer some insight into the breadth of this impact. In the 2022–2023 school year, college students with intellectual disability attending the 39 TPSID programs serving students that year received over 50,000 hours of social, academic, and work support from peer mentors (Grigal et al., 2024).

Finally, as colleges and universities prioritize enrollment, retention, and credential attainment of college students with intellectual disability, these actions build stronger

understanding across campus of the benefits of having diverse learners in these educational communities. When interviewed about the Leadership and Career Studies program at Temple University, Dr. Gregory Anderson, Professor and former Dean of the College of Education and Human Development shared this perspective about these benefits:

Having students with disabilities in classes has focused our faculty on seeing the true diversity of the learning experience and the true diversity of the student body. It's compelled our faculty to reflect on their practice, so it actually makes us better teachers. It makes us better professors. It makes us better scholars and researchers. (Stinnett et al., 2023, p. 3)

Benefits to Vocational Rehabilitation

In the United States, VR services help people who have disabilities engage in employment. The VR program in the United States is a federally funded, state-operated system providing vocational and rehabilitative services to individuals with disabilities to help them prepare for, secure, regain, or retain employment. The development and growth of college options for students with intellectual disability has potential benefits to the VR system and its practice. Postsecondary education programs assist VR in attaining its goal of helping people with intellectual disability seek and gain employment. Research using VR data documents PSE for individuals with intellectual disability is both a cost effective and cost-efficient pathway to employment (Cimera et al., 2018), with individuals with intellectual disability who pursue PSE as part of their VR services more likely to be employed and earning higher wages than their counterparts who do not pursue PSE (Miller et al., 2019; Sannicandro et al., 2018). Additionally, PSE for students with intellectual disability provides additional means for state VR to meet their own requirement of supporting more transition-aged youth by offering Pre-Employment

Transition Services (Pre-ETS). In 2014, the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA) required state VR agencies to set aside at least 15% of their federal funds to provide Pre-ETS to students with disabilities who are eligible or potentially eligible for VR services.

Required Pre-ETS include job exploration counseling, work-based learning experiences, counseling on comprehensive transition or postsecondary educational programs at institutions of higher education; workplace readiness training, and instruction in self-advocacy. These services are being implemented in partnership with high school transition programs as well as with PSE programs for students with intellectual disability. In the 2022–2023 academic year, 17 of the 27 TPSIDs partnering with VR (63%) reported collaboration with VR to provide Pre-ETS as defined in WIOA. When strong partnerships are established between colleges and universities and VR, they can help each other succeed in meeting mutual goals, including the academic and career success of college students with intellectual disability (Sulewski et al., 2021).

Benefits to Disability Funding Sources

Postsecondary education programs for students with intellectual disability use a broad array of systemic fiscal supports ranging from Medicaid waiver funds managed by a state DD agency, grants and work-study funds offered through financial aid, National Service grants, foundations, and Social Security work incentives (Grigal et al., 2024; Parisi & Landau, 2019). Tapping into a wider range of financial resources reduces the financial burden on each of these respective systems and on students and families. It also ensures these funds are being used to support services being offered in inclusive rather than segregated settings. Broadening the array of fiscal contributors in the realm of PSE also expands knowledge about these options and could potentially lead to updated state policy and regulations about use of such funds to include PSE for students with intellectual disability.

Conclusion

Postsecondary education provides a multitude of benefits for people with intellectual disability throughout their formal education years and well into their young adult lives. Students in middle and high school benefit from increased expectations, leading to targeted instruction on college readiness and self-advocacy skills. The college search process enhances student and family communication, encourages self-reflection, helps students establish personal and professional goals, and compels students to better articulate their support needs for college success. Enrolling in college benefits college students with intellectual disability by providing them a chance to build their academic and career capacity while simultaneously offering them the opportunity to determine how they want to interact in the world and personally define what disability means to them. College also helps to build social networks and social skills, and broadens students' potential to connect with peers, faculty, and employers.

College graduates with intellectual disability benefit from obtaining credentials and may be more likely to have a paid job, live independently, and have a satisfying social life. Additionally, the field of inclusive post-secondary education benefits more than just the students with intellectual disability enrolled in college. It also provides a beneficial impact on education and service systems, enhancing how higher education, VR, and other disability funding systems respond to needs of people with intellectual disability while simultaneously building each system capacity to support implementation of inclusive, outcome-oriented services. Offering PSE to individuals with intellectual disability ultimately benefits society by creating stronger and more responsive structures and building the individual's capacity to set and achieve college and career goals.

Figure 1

Number of TPSID Model Demonstration Programs and Grantees by State from 2010 to 2023

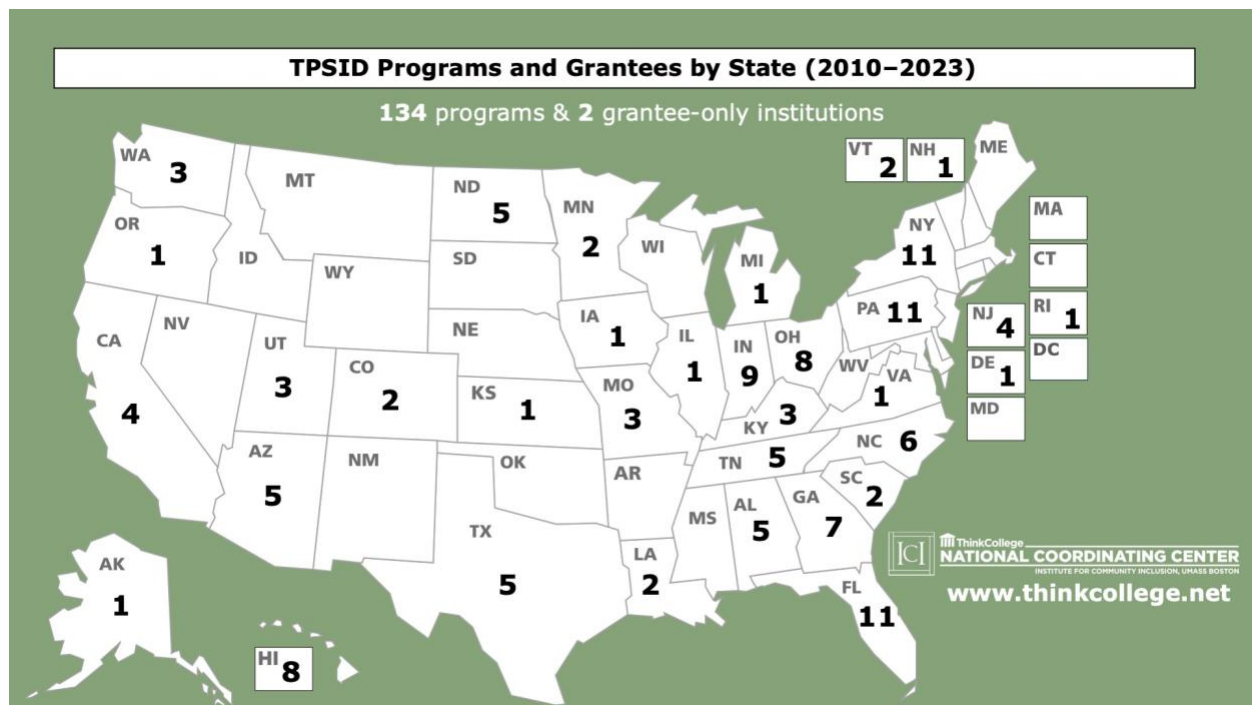
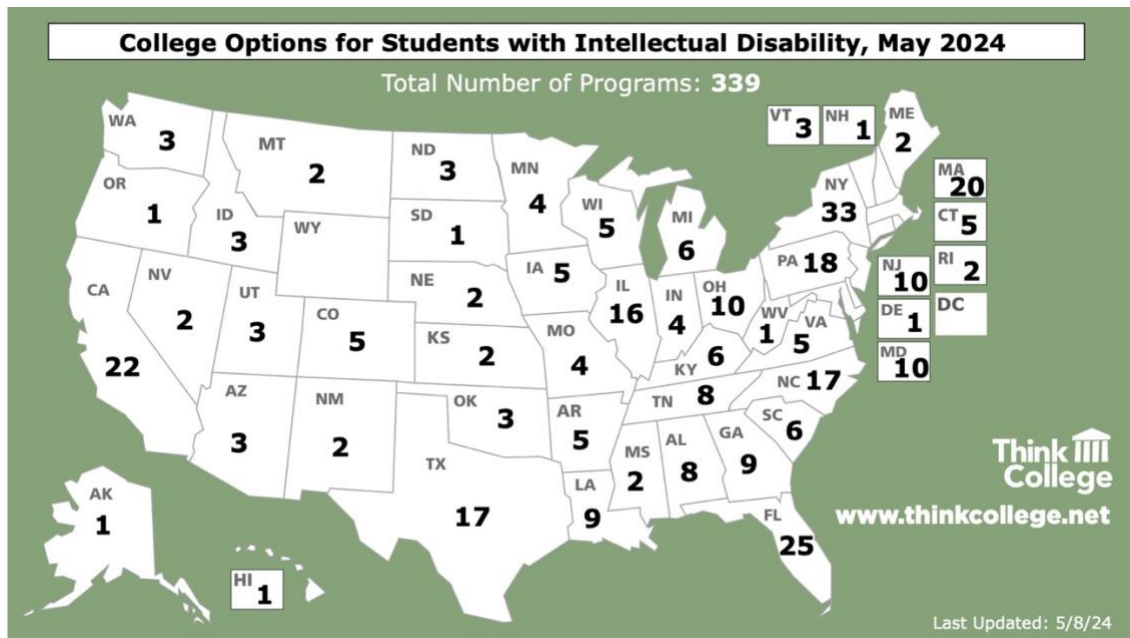


Figure 2

Number of College and University Programs Enrolling Students with Intellectual Disability by State



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